The Middle East also experienced dramatic changes during this period (the end of the 1980s and early 1990s). The Iran-Iraq War, which had lasted nearly a decade, came to an end with the Iraqis having the upper hand, though the war did not end with the Iranians' total surrender. Iraqi supremacy was achieved through the combination of chemical weapons and surface-to-surface rockets/missiles on the battlefield. The Iranians did not have a response to the chemical weapons used against them, or to the missiles and rockets that penetrated deep into Iran, including the capital, Tehran. Iran, under the rule of mullahs (educated Shiite Muslims who were trained in religious law), learned its lesson from the war and decided to build up comprehensive nonconventional strategic capabilities, including chemical, biological, and nuclear capabilities and the ability to launch strategic surface-to-surface missiles.

The First Gulf War, which broke out in 1991, was a formative event from both a regional and a global perspective. The following steps led up to it. First came the waiting period and intelligence preparations, during which the question was raised regarding whether Saddam Hussein, so soon after the conclusion of his war against Iran, would embark on another escapade. Then came the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait, followed by President George H. W. Bush's building of an impressive and broad coalition that included Saudi Arabia, Egypt, and Syria. The fact that these countries joined the coalition against Iraq, which was supported by Jordan and the Palestinians, was the last nail in the coffin of the notion of pan-Arabism in the history of the Middle East. Another step was the Israeli-American dialogue on the issue of Israel's participation in the war. President Bush urged Prime Minister Shamir not to intervene, and in exchange he promised that the US military would make taking out Iraq's surface-to-surface missile batteries a top priority. Shamir was under tremendous pressure from some of his cabinet ministers and from the IDF to take military action, but he refused, even though there were those who claimed that Saddam Hussein's apparent possession of surface-to-surface missiles armed with chemical warheads was another reason for the IDF to intervene.

Iraq launched thirty-nine surface-to-surface "Scud" missiles into Israeli territory. The US Army was unable to destroy even part of the Iraqi surface-to-surface missile system, but Prime Minister Shamir gritted his teeth and stuck to his position of nonintervention. Government ministers and IDF brass found it difficult to comprehend how Shamir, a former underground